

likely decide you don't. If you do, the amount you're asking for is for a planned purchase, so there's no opportunity to splurge beyond the boundaries.

The smashed-avocado debate has trivialised the amplitude of what you will have to give up to buy a home, which is life experiences. I still have brunch weekly – I just don't do a lot of other things, like go to the theatre or enjoy weekends away, overseas travel or exquisite restaurants. So get out your old Bali snaps and reminisce about skin-prickling heat, sweet coconut oil and marshmallow-soft resort beds – it's going to be a while between dips in a hotel pool. Kiss your frequent flyer points adieu for the (long) time being.

The trial period

It will take a month to get rolling properly on the plan, with preparation needed to make sure you don't have a stressful misstep.

Week 1

Spend as you normally would – analyse your expenditure in a normal, free-wheeling week, and learn where the wastage is.

Did you need the organic oranges, or would the regular ones be sufficient? Home-brand pasta – could you learn to enjoy it as much as the imported egg versions? Should you have bought that shampoo that was on special when you haven't finished the bottle in your shower? Would your friends have been offended if you suggested buying your own drinks at the pub instead of shouting rounds?

Note down everything – in my experience, it is the small costs that often make the greatest difference.

Week 2

Exercise discipline and test yourself – just how low can you go? This amount will be your 'pocket money'.

Run a red pen through everything in your notes from week one that was dispensable, allowing some cash for simple pleasures. For example, I have two takeaway coffees a week and have about \$50 for going out with friends.